Test Case Writing Template

Standard & Guidelines | [Organization Name] | Software Quality Assurance

1. Document Control

Document Title	Test Case Writing Template & Guidelines
Document ID	SQA-TPL-001
Version	1.0
Owner	SQA Manager
Approved By	*[Name, Designation]*
Effective Date	*[DD-MMM-YYYY]*
Review Cycle	Every 6 months, or whenever the test process changes
Applies To	All projects, SQA engineers and anyone who authors or reviews test cases

2. Purpose & Scope

This document defines one consistent way to write, review and maintain test cases across the organization. A well-written test case can be executed by any tester, produces the same result every time, and can be traced back to the requirement it proves.

Use Section 6 (blank template) for every new test case. Section 7 shows a completed example. Section 8 is the checklist reviewers must apply before a test case is approved. Section 9 provides the same fields as a column-wise grid, for teams that keep test cases in a table or spreadsheet. Where a test management tool is used, its fields should mirror this template.

3. Ten Rules for Writing Good Test Cases

1. **One objective per test case.** If a test needs the word 'and' to describe what it verifies, split it.
2. **Trace to a requirement.** Every test case links to a requirement, user story or acceptance criterion. No link, no test.
3. **Write for a stranger.** Assume the executor has never seen the module. No tribal knowledge, no 'as usual'.
4. **One action per step.** Use the imperative voice: 'Click Submit', not 'User should click Submit'.
5. **Make every expected result verifiable.** State the exact message, value, state or navigation. Avoid 'works properly' or 'as expected'.
6. **Be explicit with data.** Give the actual value or a dataset reference, never just 'valid email'.
7. **Keep tests independent and repeatable.** No reliance on execution order. Define preconditions and cleanup so the test runs the same way each time.
8. **Cover more than the happy path.** Include negative, boundary, error-handling and permission scenarios where relevant.
9. **Write for maintenance.** Do not duplicate steps across tests; reference shared preconditions and data sheets, and avoid screen details that change often.
10. **Review before baselining.** No test case is Approved until a person other than the author has reviewed it against Section 8.

Weak vs. Strong Writing

Weak	Strong	Why it is better
Check login works.	Verify that a registered user can log in with valid credentials and lands on the Dashboard.	Specific condition and observable outcome.
Enter valid data and submit.	Enter First Name = 'Anika', Email = 'anika.test@example.com'; click Submit.	Exact input; no guesswork.
System should behave properly.	Banner 'Profile updated' is displayed and the new name appears in the page header.	Measurable pass/fail criterion.

4. ID & Naming Conventions

Element	Format	Example
Test Case ID	TC-<PROJECT>-<MODULE>-<NNN>	TC-PRT-LGN-001
Title	Verify that <actor/system> <behaviour> when <condition>	Verify that a locked user cannot log in until the lock period expires
Version	Major.Minor. Minor = wording fix; Major = change in scope, steps or expected results	1.0 → 1.1 (typo) → 2.0 (new flow)

Project and module codes are 2 to 4 uppercase letters, registered in the project's test plan. IDs are never reused, even after a test case is deprecated.

5. Reference Values

Priority

Priority	Definition	Typical examples
P1 - Critical	Core business flow, security or data-integrity function. Failure blocks release.	Login, payment, data submission
P2 - High	Major feature. Failure has significant impact but a workaround exists.	Search, profile update, report export
P3 - Medium	Secondary functionality or less-used paths.	Sorting, filters, notification settings
P4 - Low	Cosmetic, minor usability issues or rarely used edge cases.	Tooltip text, alignment, label wording

Test Type

Type	Purpose
Smoke	Quick check that critical functions work in a new build; decides whether deeper testing proceeds.
Sanity	Narrow check that a specific fix or change works as intended.
Functional	Verifies behaviour against requirements and acceptance criteria.
Regression	Confirms that existing behaviour is unaffected by new changes.
Negative / Boundary	Invalid input, limits, error handling and permission checks.
Integration / API	Interaction between modules, services or third-party systems.
Security	Authentication, authorization, session and data protection.

Type	Purpose
Usability / Compatibility	User experience, accessibility, browser and device coverage.

Status Values

Test case status	Meaning
Draft	Being written by the author.
In Review	Submitted for peer or lead review.
Needs Rework	Review comments raised; author to address and resubmit.
Approved	Baselined and ready for execution.
Deprecated	No longer valid (requirement removed or changed). Retain for history; never delete.

Execution status	Rule
Pass	All steps met their expected results.
Fail	At least one step did not meet its expected result. A defect ID is mandatory.
Blocked	Cannot be executed due to an external issue. State the blocker and its defect or ticket ID.
Skipped	Intentionally not executed in this cycle. Record the reason and approver.
Not Run	Planned but not yet executed.

6. Test Case Template

Copy this section for each new test case. Grey italic text is guidance and should be replaced with real content.

A. Test Case Header

Test Case ID	*TC-<PRJ>-<MOD>-<NNN>*	**Version**	*1.0*
Test Case Title	*Verify that <actor/system> <behaviour> when <condition>*		
Project / Product	*e.g., Customer Portal*	**Module / Feature**	*e.g., Authentication*
Requirement / User Story ID	*e.g., US-1024 / REQ-AUTH-005*	**Test Type**	*Functional | Regression | Smoke | Negative | ...*
Priority	*P1 | P2 | P3 | P4*	**Automation Status**	*Manual | Automation Candidate | Automated*
Test Environment	*e.g., QA / UAT / Staging*	**Build / Release**	*e.g., v2.4.1-rc2*
Author		**Date Created**	*DD-MMM-YYYY*
Reviewer		**Status**	*Draft | In Review | Approved | Deprecated*
Automation Script Ref.	*Repo path / test name (if automated)*	**Est. Execution Time**	*e.g., 5 min*

B. Objective, Preconditions & Test Data

Objective	*One or two sentences: what is being verified and why it matters.*
Preconditions	*System state, user role, configuration and data that must exist BEFORE step 1.*
Test Data	*Specific values, or a reference to the data sheet / dataset ID.*
Dependencies	*Other test cases, services, integrations or feature flags this test relies on (if any).*

C. Test Steps

Step	Action / Procedure	Test Data / Input	Expected Result	Actual Result	Status
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					

Status values: Pass | Fail | Blocked | Skipped | Not Run

D. Postconditions / Cleanup

Postconditions	*State to restore after execution (data cleanup, unlock account, log out, etc.).*

E. Execution Record

Executed By		**Execution Date**	
Build Tested		**Overall Result**	*Pass* | *Fail* | *Blocked* | *Skipped*
Defect ID(s)		**Evidence / Attachments**	
Comments			

F. Review & Approval

Reviewed By		**Review Date**	
Approved By		**Approval Date**	

7. Worked Example

The example below is illustrative; the requirement, data and messages are fictional.

A. Test Case Header

Test Case ID	TC-PRT-LGN-003	**Version**	1.0
Test Case Title	Verify that the system locks a user account after 5 consecutive failed login attempts		
Project / Product	Customer Portal	**Module / Feature**	Authentication
Requirement / User Story ID	US-1024 / AC-3	**Test Type**	Functional (Negative)
Priority	P1 - Critical	**Automation Status**	Automation Candidate
Test Environment	QA	**Build / Release**	v2.4.1-rc2
Author	A. Rahman	**Date Created**	04-Nov-2026
Reviewer	S. Karim	**Status**	Approved
Automation Script Ref.	Not yet automated	**Est. Execution Time**	5 min

B. Objective, Preconditions & Test Data

Objective	Confirm that the account-lockout control prevents brute-force login attempts and that the user is informed of the lock.
Preconditions	1. Active user account exists with role = Customer and status = Active. 2. Account has 0 failed login attempts recorded. 3. Lockout policy configured: 5 attempts, 30-minute lock.
Test Data	Username: qa.user01@example.com Valid password: see 'LoginData' sheet, row 1 Invalid password: Wrong@123
Dependencies	Admin console access (to verify account status and to unlock the account after the test).

C. Test Steps

Step	Action / Procedure	Test Data / Input	Expected Result	Actual Result	Status
1	Open the Customer Portal login page.	URL: QA portal base URL	Login page loads with Username, Password fields and an enabled Login button.		
2	Enter the valid username and the invalid password, then click Login.	Username: qa.user01@example.com Password: Wrong@123	Error 'Invalid username or password' is displayed. User stays on the login page.		
3	Repeat step 2 four more times (5 failed attempts in total).	Same as step 2	After the 5th attempt, the message 'Your account has been locked. Try again after 30 minutes.' is displayed.		

Step	Action / Procedure	Test Data / Input	Expected Result	Actual Result	Status
4	Enter the valid username and the VALID password, then click Login.	Valid password from 'LoginData' sheet	Login is denied. The account-locked message is displayed again.		
5	In the Admin console, open the user record for the test account.	Admin > Users > qa.user01@example.com	Status = Locked. Lock timestamp is recorded. An audit-log entry exists for the lockout event.		

Status values: Pass | Fail | Blocked | Skipped | Not Run

D. Postconditions / Cleanup

Postconditions	Unlock the account in the Admin console and reset failed-attempt count to 0 so the data is ready for the next run.

E. Execution Record

Executed By		**Execution Date**	
Build Tested		**Overall Result**	Pass | Fail | Blocked | Skipped
Defect ID(s)		**Evidence / Attachments**	
Comments			

F. Review & Approval

Reviewed By		**Review Date**	
Approved By		**Approval Date**	

8. Test Case Review Checklist

The reviewer confirms every item before moving a test case to Approved. Any unchecked item returns the test case to the author as Needs Rework.

No.	Checklist item	Yes / No	N/A
1	Linked to a requirement, user story or acceptance criterion.	☐	☐
2	ID and title follow the naming convention; the title is unique and describes one objective.	☐	☐
3	Objective, preconditions and test data are complete and specific.	☐	☐
4	Steps are atomic, ordered logically and written in the imperative voice.	☐	☐
5	Every verification point has a specific, measurable expected result.	☐	☐
6	Negative, boundary and permission scenarios are covered where relevant.	☐	☐
7	No duplicate of an existing test case; shared steps are referenced, not copied.	☐	☐
8	Priority, test type and automation status are assigned correctly.	☐	☐
9	Postconditions restore the system so the test is repeatable.	☐	☐
10	No vague wording such as 'properly', 'correctly', 'as expected' or 'etc.'.	☐	☐
11	Spelling, grammar and terminology are consistent with the product.	☐	☐
12	Reviewed by someone other than the author.	☐	☐

Reviewer		**Date**	
Decision	*Approved* | *Needs Rework*	**Comments**	

9. Column-wise Test Case Template

One row per test case. Use this grid when test cases are kept in a table or spreadsheet, or when importing into a test management tool. Number steps inside the Test Steps cell (1, 2, 3...) and keep each step to a single action. The shaded row is an example; delete it before use.

TC ID	Module	Req. ID	Test Case Title	Test Type	Priority	Preconditions	Test Steps	Test Data	Expected Result	Actual Result	Status	Defect ID	Auto Status	Author
TC-PRT-LGN-003	*Login*	*US-1024*	*Verify account locks after 5 consecutive failed logins*	*Negative*	*P1*	*Active customer account with 0 failed attempts; lockout policy = 5 attempts / 30 min*	*1. Open login page.* *2. Enter valid username and wrong password; click Login.* *3. Repeat step 2 four more times.* *4. Enter valid password; click Login.*	*User: qa.user01* *Bad pwd: Wrong@1*	*2. 'Invalid username or password' shown.* *3. Account-locked message shown on 5th attempt.* *4. Login denied; locked message shown.*		*Not Run*		*Candidate*	*A. Rahman*

Column Guide

Column	What to enter	Allowed values / format
TC ID	Unique ID following TC-<PROJECT>-<MODULE>-<NNN>. Never reused.	e.g., TC-PRT-LGN-001
Module	Application area or feature the test belongs to.	As defined in the test plan
Req. ID	Requirement, user story or acceptance criterion the test proves.	e.g., US-1024, REQ-AUTH-005
Test Case Title	One objective, written as 'Verify that <actor/system> <behaviour> when <condition>'.	Unique within the project
Test Type	Nature of the test.	Smoke | Sanity | Functional | Regression | Negative | Integration | Security | Usability
Priority	Business and risk importance.	P1 | P2 | P3 | P4
Preconditions	System state, role, configuration and data required before step 1.	Free text, numbered if more than one
Test Steps	Numbered, single-action steps in the imperative voice.	1., 2., 3. ...
Test Data	Exact values or a data sheet / dataset reference.	No vague entries such as 'valid email'
Expected Result	Specific, verifiable outcome. Reference the step number it belongs to.	Exact message, value, state or navigation
Actual Result	What happened during execution. Fill at execution time only.	Blank until executed
Status	Execution outcome for the current cycle.	Pass | Fail | Blocked | Skipped | Not Run
Defect ID	Defect or ticket raised for a Fail, or the blocker for a Blocked test.	Mandatory when Fail or Blocked
Auto Status	Automation state of the test.	Manual | Candidate | Automated
Author	Person who wrote the test case.	Name or initials

Tip: if your tool needs more fields (reviewer, version, environment, estimated time), append them as extra columns using the same naming style as Section 6.